GinCol Lab · Aula

Teacher sheets

Contemporary World History · 1st year of Bachillerato · The historian's craft · Class 4 of 6 · With Tristán

1789: did everything change for everyone?

Class video: https://youtu.be/jcWJABA81hM

This sheet online: https://gincollab.github.io/aula/en/historia-mundo-contemporaneo/t01-c4/

The code leads to the video.

In a nutshell

Two more tools of the craft: **seeing what changes and what stays the same, and deciding which events matter**. The case is the date the textbooks start with: 1789. In August, at Versailles, an assembly writes "Men are born and remain free and equal in rights"; French women will wait 155 years for a law to give them the vote. Did everything change, and for everyone?

The class puts the date to the test with documents. **Everything?** The August decree "entirely destroys the feudal regime", but in the same article it declares the other dues "redeemable", and says they "will continue to be collected"; the law of May 1790 sets the price (twenty or twenty-five times what was paid each year); many peasants stop paying, and the law does not abolish the dues without compensation until July 1793. The announcement, the law and the people: each at its own pace. At the top, regimes change again and again; at the bottom, the France that lives in the countryside hardly moves (Braudel, from class 3). **For everyone?** The Declaration says "all citizens", but Sieyès separates active and passive citizens; the vote, counted out of every hundred people, goes from 16 (1791) to 0.3 (1817) and to 28 (1848), and women do not have it until 1944; slavery, abolished in 1794, returns in Guadeloupe in 1802. With that, the typical mistake falls, **to change is to improve**, with Condorcet's text in front of us and the fact separated from the judgement. **Why 1789?** Four questions for arguing significance (Seixas and Morton, building on Partington), what did not last (decimal time, the calendar) and what did (the metre; the sentence of 1789, in 1948 and in 1978), the ages as a convention (1789 here, 1945 in English) and significance that changes with our questions. The answer: not everything, not for everyone, and not all at once; but it changed so much, for so many people and for so long, that many historians start a new age there.

Objective. By the end, students will be able to recognise what changes and what stays the same in a historical process, and at what pace; tell change from progress; and argue with criteria why an event is significant, and why the textbooks open the Contemporary Age with 1789.

> **A note on the answer.** The class does not decide whether 1789 "deserves" to open the Contemporary Age: it gives the criteria for arguing it and shows that it is historians who draw the line. Exercise 3 and the open question leave the judgement to the students.

For readers outside Spain: the Bachillerato is the last two years of secondary school (ages 16–18). Contemporary World History is an elective in the first year of the Humanities and Social Sciences track. Spanish (and French) textbooks divide history into ages and usually start the Contemporary Age (*Edad Contemporánea*) in 1789; in English, "contemporary history" usually starts in 1945, and the class makes a point of it. The video is in Spanish, with English subtitles; the images on this sheet come from the video and keep their Spanish text. The translations of French and Spanish documents (the decrees, the cahiers de doléances, Sieyès, Condorcet, the curriculum, the newspapers) are our own and literal; the Declaration of 1789 is quoted in the official English translation of the Conseil constitutionnel, and English texts are quoted in the original.

Curriculum

Spain's Royal Decree 243/2022, Contemporary World History, an elective in the first year of the Bachillerato in Humanities and Social Sciences (consolidated text in the Official State Gazette, BOE, checked on 21/10/2026; last updated 02/07/2026). Our translation of the official Spanish text. The description of competence 1 asks for an understanding of "the relationship between the slower, more structural factors and the conjunctures of change" and for the adoption of "a not strictly linear perspective on the course of history, identifying advances and setbacks"; that of competence 8 recalls that "the history that is written pays more attention to the exceptional and individual events and figures who play the leading part in the great changes than to continuities and to anonymous subjects, who tend to go unnoticed". That is exactly what this class does.

Element	What the decree says	Where the class works on it
Core knowledge (block A, "Societies in time")	"The historian's work: historical sources, historiography and narratives of the past. Historical argument. Significance, causes and consequences, change and continuity. [...]"	The whole class: change and continuity, with their paces; change versus progress; significance with criteria; the ages as an interpretation

Element	What the decree says	Where the class works on it
Core knowledge (block A)	"The struggle for freedom, change and revolution in the contemporary era: from the bourgeois revolutions to the socialist revolutions. [...]" · "The historical and political meaning of nationalisms in the contemporary world: from servitude to citizenship. Abolitionism [...]"	1789 as a case: the August decree, the Declaration, who could vote, and slavery (1794, 1802, 1848)
Specific competences 1 and 8	"To recognise the movements, actions and historical transformations that have contributed to the consolidation of freedom [...]" · "To describe and analyse the changes and continuities that have taken place in contemporary society [...] paying special attention to the situation of women [...]"	The concepts of change, pace, progress, significance and periodisation; the regimes versus life in the countryside; votes for women
Criterion 1.2	"To understand the concepts of revolution and change in the contemporary world and the elements and factors that cause and condition them [...]"	What changed in 1789, what did not, and at what pace
Criterion 8.1	"To analyse the changes and continuities in history, paying attention to longer-term processes, such as demographic behaviour, life cycles and ways of life [...]"	Slow time (the countryside, from about 80 to about 76 in every 100 in almost sixty years); Sieyès's "passive" citizens
Criterion 8.2 (in full)	"To contrast the relegated role of women in contemporary history, identifying and valuing the importance of individual and collective figures as anonymous protagonists of contemporary history, as well as the role of feminist movements in the recognition of their rights and in the achievement of effective equality between women and men, as well as co-responsibility in the care of people."	The relegated role: Sieyès, 1791, 1848 and the 1944 ordinance. A figure: Hansa Mehta. The collective side, only as a pointer: the UN commission on women in 1948 ("For teachers"); class 6 comes back to it with Olympe de Gouges. Care is not worked on here

What students need to bring. The four questions for a source (class 1), which today are put to the Declaration, and Braudel and his slow time (class 3). From lower secondary (ESO; Royal Decree 217/2022, Geography and History, years 3 and 4): "Historical time: construction and interpretation of timelines through linearity, chronology, simultaneity and duration" and "The political transformation of human beings: from servitude to citizenship. Transitions, revolutions and resistance: continuities and changes in the contemporary era". The class gives the essentials in one minute: the estates, the privileges and the summer of 1789.

Where it comes back. In the current plan, topic 2 ("The end of the Ancien Régime: the liberal revolutions") covers the Ancien Régime from the inside, the causes of 1789, the full commentary on the Declaration and census suffrage (the vote restricted by wealth). Here 1789 is a case for learning to look at change and significance; there, it is the content. Class 5 continues with two historians who disagree, and class 6 with Olympe de Gouges and the question of whether the past can be judged.

How the class is built

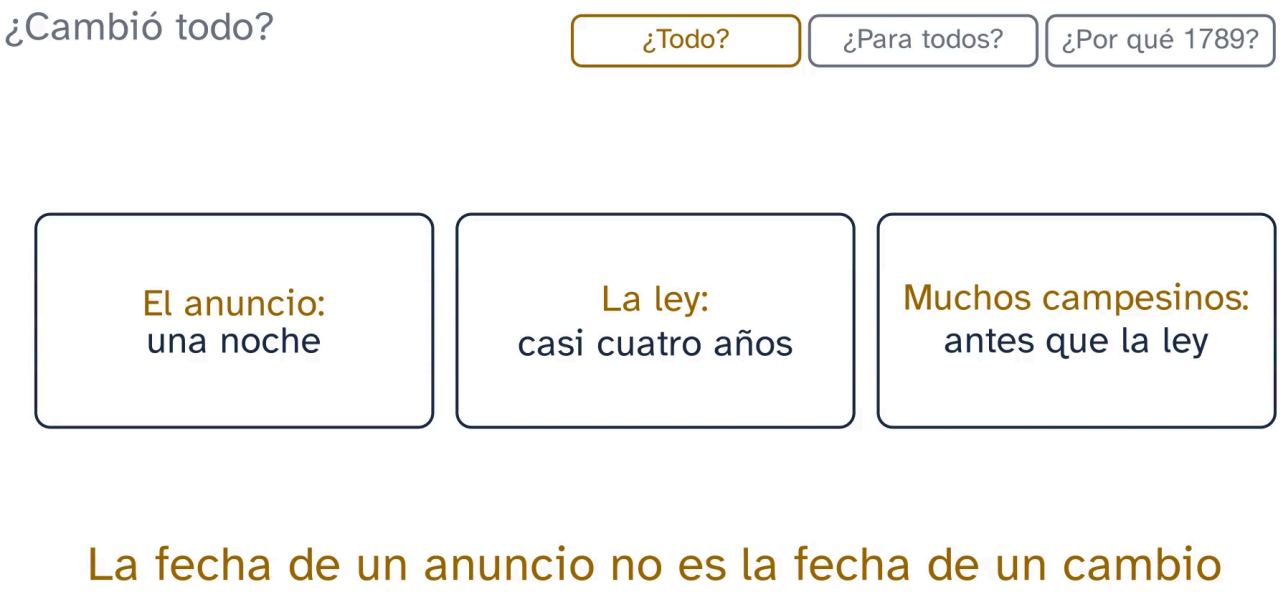
Video chapters

Minute	Chapter
0:00	What we'll see
0:46	What you already know
2:50	1789 in a minute
4:22	Did everything change?
6:42	Fast time, slow time
8:00	For everyone?
11:15	Change is not improvement
12:39	Why 1789?
15:55	Practice and keep thinking

In nine chapters, 17:48. The title question is split into three boxes (Everything?, For everyone?, Why 1789?) that light up on reaching each part and at the end fill with their answer, so that the thread is not lost.

Chapter	What happens	Why this way
What we'll see	Tristán, at his desk; the map of the topic; 1789, Versailles and Article 1 of the Declaration, typed out. The hook: "French women waited 155 years for a law to give them the vote. Did everything change, and for everyone?"	The question comes from the clash between the famous sentence and a fact
What you already know	The four questions from class 1, which are used today; the solutions from class 3, each with its exercise restated	Retrieving what will be needed; closing the spaced practice
1789 in a minute	560 dots of 50,000 people each: the privileged, one and a half in every hundred (Piketty); Sieyès and his pamphlet; the summer, date by date	The essentials, without taking anything from topic 2; people, not percentages
Did everything change?	The peasant who pays three; the August decree; the bet; the article read in full, with a highlighter; the redemption poster (1790); 1793; three paces in three boxes	The document before the conclusion. The bet commits students to a hypothesis (White and Gunstone, 1992), as in class 3, and the source itself resolves it
Fast time, slow time	At the top, the regimes that jump; at the bottom, a hundred dots that hardly move (from about 80 to about 76 in the countryside). Braudel	Two times at once, on the same screen. "Change is a process, with varying paces and patterns" (Seixas and Morton, 2013)
For everyone?	Articles 1 and 6 of the Declaration; the stop-and-think; Sieyès's draft; the vote out of every hundred (16, "?", 0.3, 28); the 1944 ordinance; slavery, from 1794 to 1848, with Haiti	Counting out of every hundred and seeing the groups one by one is what no general video does (this class's review of reference videos)

Chapter	What happens	Why this way
Change is not improvement	Condorcet, in hiding, writes that the march of progress "will never be retrograde"; the arrow of progress bends over the vote; fact and judgement	The mistake, with its text, taken apart with what the student has just seen
Why 1789?	The four questions of significance, applied to 1789; what did not last (decimal time, the calendar) and what did (the metre, the sentence in 1948 and in 1978, Hansa Mehta); the ages; significance that changes; the answer to the title	A single date goes through all the criteria. The ages, as a tool and not as a fact
Practice and keep thinking	Summary in three cards, three exercises that mix this class with the earlier ones, and the open question	The open question, without a verdict



The announcement, the law and the people: each at its own pace.

A plan for a 50-minute lesson

Minutes	What to do
0–4	No video, the bet from the worksheet in writing: a peasant, in 1790: does he stop paying his lord? Each student chooses one of the three options and writes why.
4–13	Video to the bet in "Did everything change?" (5:11): pairs compare it with what they wrote. Carry on to the end of the chapter (6:42).
13–23	"Fast time, slow time" and "For everyone?" up to the Article 6 pause (8:41): each pair writes down who "all citizens" were. Carry on to the end of "For everyone?" (11:15) and fill in the vote table on the worksheet.
23–30	"Change is not improvement" and "Why 1789?" (to 15:55). After "fact and judgement", stop and do question 3 of the vote table: the same fact, with another criterion.
30–46	The activity: "What two villages asked for" (below).
46–50	Video to the end. The exercises, for homework.

Typical mistakes and how they are handled

Mistake	What the research says	How the class handles it
"To change is to improve": history always moves forward	"There is some evidence from research that students tend to think of the direction of change as automatically involving progress"; that idea can lead to "a condescending attitude toward the past", which is seen only in terms of deficits (Lee, 2005, pp. 44–45). Seixas and Morton: progress and decline are "broad evaluations of change over time", and "progress for one people may be decline for another" (2013, p. 10)	Condorcet, with his text, set against the vote (from 16 in every 100 to 3 in every 1,000) and slavery returning in Guadeloupe; the arrow of progress bends. And the fact, separated from the judgement: "step backwards" is a judgement with a criterion

Mistake	What the research says	How the class handles it
"One event changed everything at a stroke" ("feudalism was abolished on 4 August")	"If students see changes as events", the idea of "gradual, unintended changes" "is not available to them", and change is seen as "episodic" and "intentional" (Lee, 2005, p. 44). The most-watched videos repeat the sentence: Crash Course #29 (3:10–3:25), and *The Rest Is History* has it in an episode title	Article 1 of the decree, read in full: "entirely destroys" and, in the same article, "redeemable" and "will continue to be collected". Three paces in three boxes: the announcement, the law and the people
"The Declaration was for everyone"	The most-watched videos say so: "applied to every person" (Crash Course #29, 3:25–3:36, more than 10 million views); "derechos para todos" ("rights for everyone"; Infonimados, 6:33)	The fourth question for a source, with a twist: who was it for? Sieyès's "passive" citizens, the vote out of every hundred and each group on its own date
"The ages are in the past": the Contemporary Age begins in 1789 just because	Periodization "is a process of interpretation" (Seixas and Morton, 2013, p. 10). Many videos present it as natural (unProfesor, Happy Learning, Memorias de Pez)	Two timelines: 1789 in Spain and in France, 1945 in English. "Ages are not in the past: they are a tool for putting it in order"
"It's important because it's in the textbook" (or "because I'm interested in it")	The Historical Thinking Project calls the two sentences ("It is significant because it is in the history book," and "It is significant because I am interested in it") "inadequate explanations of historical significance". And it is what gets least work: in the Spanish first-year Bachillerato textbooks analysed (three publishers, alongside three British ones), significance is the least worked-on competence, in 8.7% of the activities (Campillo-Ferrer, Sánchez-Ibáñez and Castro-Fernández, 2025)	Four questions for arguing it, applied to a single date; and significance that changes with our questions (the peasants, women, enslaved people)

Questions and solutions

Stop and think (in the video)

- *Before you trust a source, you ask it four questions. What are they?* (0:51) Who made it, when and where, what for and for whom (class 1). Today they come back with the Declaration, and the fourth one with a twist.
- *The bet: a peasant, in 1790: does he stop paying his lord?* (4:54) By law, option 2. In August 1789 the dues tied to mortmain and personal servitude fell without compensation, and in March 1790 the banalités (the compulsory mill and oven) and personal labour services. But what was paid for the land (the cens, the champart, the dues on sales) was "redeemable" and went on being collected until 17 July 1793. In practice, many stopped paying earlier: "dès le premier moment de la révolution, le paysan était décidé à ne plus payer" ("from the very first moment of the revolution, the peasant was determined to pay no more"; Lefebvre, 1929, p. 140). Option 1 is what many did, not what the law said. Option 3 has no general evidence, although anyone who redeemed paid all at once and with arrears.
- *Who was it for? Who were all the citizens?* (8:34) The Declaration does not say. The clue is Sieyès's draft: "passive" citizens, protected but without a vote (women, "at least in the present state", children, foreigners and those who did not contribute to sustaining the State), and "active" citizens, who elect. The rule came with the Constitution of 1791: men aged 25 or over who paid a contribution worth three days' work, were not servants and had taken the oath; about 16 in every 100 inhabitants. It does not mention women when it grants the vote: it was taken for granted that they did not vote.



The arrow of "progress", bent over the vote: 16 in every 100 in 1791, 0.3 in 1817 and 28 in 1848.

From the student worksheet

- *While you watch the video.* 1) That the dues tied to mortmain and personal servitude are abolished without compensation; everything else is "rachetable", redeemable (it has to be bought out), and meanwhile "will continue to be collected". 2) Twenty times what was paid each year; twenty-five if it was paid in kind (letters patent of 9-5-1790, art. XXI). Without compensation, on 17-7-1793. 3) The announcement, in one night (4-8-1789); the law, almost four years (1,443 days); many peasants, before the law. 4) Fast, the regime; slowly, where people live: in the countryside, about 80 in every 100 around 1789 (an estimate) and about 76 in 1846. 5) Women, children, foreigners and those who did not contribute to sustaining the State; it was a draft, not an approved text. 6) How much it changed people's lives; how many people it reached; for how long; what it reveals to us, about the past or about today.
- *The vote, out of every hundred.* 1) 16; "?" (nobody counted: "aucun document ne fixe le total des électeurs inscrits", "no document establishes the total number of registered voters", Meuriot, 1916, p. 159); 0.3; 28. 2) Backwards: from 16 in every 100 to 3 in every 1,000. 3) Forwards: from fewer than 2 in every 1,000 to about 3 in every 1,000, almost double (Meuriot, pp. 158 and 221–233; calculated). The same facts give "step backwards" or "step forwards" depending on the criterion: what counts is that students say which one they are using, not that they declare one of them "the true one".
- *Fast, slow or hardly at all?* 1) F (on paper). 2) S: it went on being collected until 1793, although many stopped paying earlier. 3) F: fast time. 4) H: from about 80 to about 76 in every 100 in 57 years; "hardly at all" is not "not at all". 5) B, by the criterion "who is free": abolished in 1794 and restored by force in 1802. 6) S: law of 1795, the only measure allowed from 1-1-1840. The final question is open: what counts is that students use a criterion (for example, "how many people": what was paid for the land affected the majority).

Practice (the solutions open class 5)

1. *An oral source: a day in the life of an older person in the family when they were your age.* Open-ended. Criteria: three changes and three continuities, each with its reason; if something has got "worse", with its criterion and for whom; and some sign of pace (what changed at a stroke and what little by little). It is a source, and it is questioned: memory reconstructs. With permission, and without publishing anything private.
2. *Spain: women's first vote in a general election (1933) and the years without free general elections, between those of February 1936 and those of June 1977. The timeline, where it went backwards and by what criterion.* Fact, criterion and judgement, separately.
3. **The facts**, without adjectives. 19-11-1933: the first general election in which women vote (Constitution of 1931, art. 36: "los ciudadanos de uno y de otro sexo, mayores de veintitrés años", "citizens of either sex, over twenty-three years of age"). 16-2-1936: the last general election before the war. Between it and the June 1977 election there are no free general elections: the parties, dissolved (decree of 19-4-1937); referendums in 1947 and 1966 (men and women aged 21 or over) and, from 1967, the "family third" (*tercio familiar*: heads of family and married women), without parties. 15-6-1977: free general elections, with men and women of full age voting (then, 21).

4. **A criterion, stated**: for example, "how many people can freely elect their deputies". With it, the line drops to zero after February 1936, for women and for men, and comes back in 1977. **The judgement**: calling it a "step backwards" is a judgement with that criterion; with another ("who votes in any vote at all"), the referendums included men and women. That is why the exact word is "free".
5. **What does not work**: "there was never any voting"; "Franco took the vote away from women" as a sentence on its own (free elections disappeared, for everyone); and "the 1936 elections were the last free elections" as a closed statement, because they have their own debate among historians: what is certain is that between them and those of 1977 there were none. If someone goes further back, the line also comes and goes: 1868, men aged 25 or over; 1878, only those who paid a tax quota; 1890, all men again; 1923–1930, no general elections.
6. *The four questions of significance, applied to the opening of the Wall. As significant as 1789?* Open-ended. How much it changed: for East Germans, a great deal and fast (free elections on 18-3-1990 and a single country on 3-10-1990, class 3). How many people: the two German states straight away; beyond that, it depends on how it is related to the end of the Eastern bloc regimes and of the USSR (topic 16), and that is an interpretation. For how long: Germany has remained united since 1990. What it reveals to us: one possible reading is that a regime can fall without a war, or that chance sometimes decides the when and the how (class 3). The comparison has no textbook answer: what counts is that students use the same criteria for both and say where they are looking from, because significance "varies over time and from group to group" (Seixas and Morton, 2013). For the debate: in the small hours of that same night, *ABC* wrote that "con este hecho histórico comienza un período fundamental, a juicio de los observadores internacionales, dentro de la historia contemporánea" ("with this historic event begins a fundamental period, in the view of international observers, within contemporary history"; 10-11-1989, p. 1). Contemporaries also decide what is "historic"; later, historians revise it.

Keep thinking. *In a hundred years' time, a historian writes about our era. Of everything you have lived through, which event would they choose, and by what criterion?* It has no textbook answer. Some pointers, without closing it: the "for how long" question cannot be answered yet, and that is why historians need distance; Partington added a criterion that the class does not use, the importance people at the time gave it, which for our own era we can answer (as reported by Hunt, 2000, and Phillips, 2002); significance "is constructed" and "varies" (Seixas and Morton, 2013). If someone chooses a personal event, it is fair to ask them how many people it affected: the criterion is discussed, not their private life. The teacher moderates and does not give a verdict.

A classroom activity: what two villages asked for

Duration: 16 minutes. **Materials:** two cahiers de doléances (lists of grievances) from April 1789 and the laws that answered them, open on Persée and the Internet Archive; below, the excerpts with their translation, for printing. The French of the 1879 edition, with modernised spelling, reads easily with the glossary.

The documents

- **A. Gres-en-Brie** ("paroisse de Grés en Brie, bailliage de Paris"), cahier approved at the inhabitants' assembly on 13 April 1789. *Archives parlementaires*, 1st series, vol. IV (1879), pp. 592–594: https://www.persee.fr/doc/arcpa_0000-0000_1879_num_4_1_2205
- "Il est de la dernière importance que les droits de champart, dans les lieux où ils sont étendus, soient totalement abolis" ("It is of the utmost importance that the champart dues, in the places where they extend, be totally abolished").
- "La dîme [...] se perçoit partout inégalement [...]. Elle devrait être perçue uniformément, et à raison de quatre gerbes par arpent" ("The tithe [...] is collected unequally everywhere [...]. It ought to be collected uniformly, at the rate of four sheaves per *arpent*").
- "le lapin et les bêtes de grande chasse ravageaient nos récoltes" ("the rabbit and the big game were ravaging our crops").
- To the nobility and the clergy: "répartir sur vous comme sur nous l'impôt en parfaite égalité, et chacun en proportion de ses possessions" ("to apportion the tax on you as on us, in perfect equality, and each in proportion to what he possesses").
- **B. Sceaux-Penthièvre**, "près Paris", general assembly of the parish on 12 April 1789, Easter Sunday. *Archives parlementaires*, 1st series, vol. V (1879), pp. 115–116: https://www.persee.fr/doc/arcpa_0000-0000_1879_num_5_1_2410
- Art. 5: "Que la suppression de tous les privilèges soit opérée" ("That the abolition of all privileges be carried out").
- Arts. 8, 11 and 12: that the hunting preserves ("capitaineries") and the right to keep dovecotes be abolished, and that the rabbits be destroyed.
- Art. 9: "Qu'il soit permis de faire le rachat des dîmes en un abonnement en argent" ("That it be permitted to redeem the tithes by a fixed payment in money").
- Art. 10: "Qu'il en soit de même pour le rachat des champarts et surcens seigneuriaux, et pour le rachat de toutes rentes seigneuriales" ("That the same apply to the redemption of seigneurial champarts and surcens, and to the redemption of all seigneurial rents").
- Art. 18: "Que toutes les mesures soient réduites à une seule" ("That all measures be reduced to a single one").
- At the foot, it is signed by the inhabitants "qui le savent, et les autres ont déclaré ne le savoir" ("who know how [to sign]; the others declared that they did not know how").
- **C. The law.** The August 1789 decree, arts. 1, 2, 3, 5, 6 and 9 (*Archives parlementaires*, vol. VIII, pp. 397–398: https://www.persee.fr/doc/arcpa_0000-0000_1875_num_8_1_4833_t2_0397_0000_3); the poster of 9 May 1790, art. XXI, with the price of redemption (https://archive.org/details/case_oversize_frc_10460_no_03); the law of April 1790, which stops collecting the tithes from 1 January 1791; the decree of 17 July 1793, art. 1 (*Archives parlementaires*, vol. LXIX, p. 98: https://archive.org/details/archivesparlemen69pariuoft); and the metre, law of 1795, compulsory from 1840.

Glossary: *champart*, the share of the harvest that the lord took; *dîme*, tithe; *capitaineries* and *remises*, hunting preserves and game cover; *rachat*, redemption (paying to be free of a charge); *surcens*, an additional cens, on top of the first; *arpent*, a measure of area that each place measured in its own way.

Steps

1. (2 min) Groups of three; half get Gres-en-Brie, and the other half Sceaux-Penthièvre. The four questions to the cahier: who made it? when and where? what for? for whom? Who signs? Who does not appear?
2. (7 min) With documents C, a table: *grievance · what the village asked for · what the law said, and when · at a stroke, slowly or not at all? · more than, the same as or less than what was asked?*
3. (4 min) Pooling: the champart of the two villages, side by side. Gres asked for it to be abolished; Sceaux, to be able to redeem it. Which one did the law of 1789–1790 agree with? And that of 1793? What does that say about "the peasants" as if they were a single bloc?
4. (3 min) Significance with a criterion: which change was the most significant for these villagers? Each group chooses one and defends it with one of the four questions; on the board, each group's criterion.

Solutions

Grievance	Gres-en-Brie	Sceaux-Penthièvre	What the law said	Pace	Compared with what was asked?
Champart	Abolish it "totally" (or, "at least", moderate it equally in all the provinces)	Be able to redeem it (art. 10)	1789: redeemable (art. 6) and still collected (art. 1); price and method, in 1790; abolished without compensation on 17-7-1793 (except rents that were "purely land-based and not feudal", art. 2)	Slow: almost four years	Sceaux, what it asked for, in 1789–1790; Gres, in 1793
Tithe	Collect it equally everywhere, or pay the priests some other way	Redeem it with a fixed money payment (art. 9)	Abolished in August 1789 (art. 5), without redemption, but collected until 31-12-1790	Announced at a stroke; ended almost a year and a half later	More than was asked, but not at a stroke

Grievance	Gres-en-Brie	Sceaux-Penthièvre	What the law said	Pace	Compared with what was asked?
Hunting	Rabbits and big game ravage the crops	Abolish the preserves (art. 8) and destroy the rabbits (art. 11)	Art. 3: the exclusive right of hunting and the preserves abolished, "even royal ones"; "every owner" may destroy game "only on his possessions"	At a stroke, on paper	What was asked. But for everyone? The right belongs to the owner, on his land
Dovecotes	—	Abolish the dovecote right (art. 12)	Art. 2: "The exclusive right" to dovecotes "is abolished"; the pigeons shut in at the times set by the community	At a stroke, on paper	What was asked
Privileges and equal taxation	Tax for everyone, "in perfect equality"	Abolish all privilege (art. 5)	Art. 9: tax privileges abolished "for ever"; tax will be levied on all citizens and all property "in the same manner"	At a stroke, on paper	What was asked
A single measure	—	"all measures [...] to a single one" (art. 18)	Law of 1795 (the metre); the only measure allowed from 1-1-1840 (law of 4-7-1837)	Very slow: almost 51 years from the cahier	What was asked, half a century later

Wrap-up. The cahiers do not speak for "the peasants": two parishes on the outskirts of Paris asked for different things for the same charge. The law answered at different paces: hunting and dovecotes, at a stroke and on paper; the tithe, in a year and a half; the champart, in four years; a single measure, in half a century. And not always for everyone: the right to hunt on one's land belonged to the owner. For context: in 748 parish cahiers, eight of the ten most frequent grievances were about the state's taxes: "d'abord les impôts, encore les impôts, toujours les impôts" ("taxes first, taxes again, taxes always"; Markoff, 1991, p. 59).

Do it yourself: the *Archives parlementaires* collection on Persée has, in its first volumes, the 1789 cahiers de doléances of many parishes, with text search. Search for "cahier" and the name of a village, and repeat the table. *Poster variant:* project the 1790 poster (Newberry Library) and zoom in to find article XXI: how much would it cost to be free of a rent of 10 livres a year? (200 livres at once, plus arrears; if it was paid in grain, twenty-five times one year's payment.)

Open resources

Checked on 21/10/2026, free and without registration.

Resource	What it offers	Link
Persée, *Archives parlementaires* (Sorbonne library)	The 1789 cahiers de doléances, the decrees and the Assembly's debates, with text search, in French	https://www.persee.fr/collection/arcpa

Resource	What it offers	Link
Internet Archive, Newberry Library French Pamphlets	More than 38,000 French printed items, mostly from 1780 to 1810; among them, the 1790 redemption poster	https://archive.org/details/newberryfrenchpamphlets
Conseil constitutionnel	The 1789 Declaration, in French and in its official English translation; the Constitutions of France	https://www.conseil-constitutionnel.fr/en/declaration-of-hum rights-of-26-august-1789
Digithèque MJP (University of Perpignan)	The constitutions and laws of France: 1791, the 1944 ordinance, the decrees of 1794 and 1848 and the 1802 law on slavery, in French	https://mjp.univ-perp.fr/france/

Resource	What it offers	Link
Assemblée nationale, "Le suffrage universel"	The history of voting in France and of how women won the vote, with its chronology, in French	https://www2.assemblee-nationale.fr/decouvrir-l-assemblee/suffrage-universel
Fondation pour la mémoire de l'esclavage	1791, 1794, 1802 and 1848, with documents, in French	https://memoire-esclavage.org/
French Wikisource	Sieyès, *Qu'est-ce que le tiers état ?* (1888 ed.); Condorcet's *Esquisse* in facsimile (1795); Tocqueville	https://fr.wikisource.org/wiki/Qu%E2%80%99est-ce_que_le_tiers_%C3%A9tat_%3F_(Champion,_1888)/Qu%E2%80%99est-ce_que_le_tiers_%C3%A9tat_%3F
Liberty, Equality, Fraternity (George Mason University and CUNY)	350 texts, 250 images, 13 songs and 13 maps of the Revolution	https://revolution.chnm.org/

Resource	What it offers	Link
Historical Thinking Project	Significance, and continuity and change, with their criteria	https://historicalthinking.ca/historical-significance
United Nations	The Universal Declaration; the records of its drafting (for example, E/CN.4/SR.34, with Hansa Mehta) and the women who wrote it	https://www.un.org/en/about-us/universal-declaration-of-hun

Resource	What it offers	Link
Congreso de los Diputados	"Elecciones 19 noviembre 1933" (the elections of 19 November 1933) and "La diputada Campoamor y los derechos civiles y políticos de las mujeres" (Deputy Campoamor and women's civil and political rights), in Spanish, for exercise 2	https://www.congreso.es/es/cem/iirep-nov-1933
BOE, Gazeta (historical collection)	The provisions of Spain's official gazettes from 1661 to 1959: the 1931 Constitution, the 1849 law on the metre, in Spanish	https://www.boe.es/buscar/gazeta.php

For teachers: what does not fit in the video

- **Condorcet himself defended votes for women.** In 1790: "Ou aucun individu de l'espèce humaine n'a de véritables droits, ou tous ont les mêmes ; et celui qui vote contre le droit d'un autre, quels que soient sa religion, sa couleur ou son sexe, a dès lors abjuré les siens" ("Either no individual of the human species has true rights, or all have the same; and he who votes against the right of another, whatever his religion, his colour or his sex, has from that moment abjured his own"; *Journal de la Société de 1789*, no. V, 3-7-1790; *Œuvres*, vol. X, 1847, p. 122). In the end he proposed starting with women who owned property. It helps not to turn him into a straw man. And his "jamais rétrograde" speaks of the future, of a perfectibility "désormais indépendante de toute puissance qui voudroit les arrêter" ("henceforth independent of any power that might wish to halt [its progress]"; *Esquisse*, 1795, p. 4): the decades that followed are a fair test of his prediction.
- **The twist of the criterion.** In 1791, the 16 in every 100 only voted at the first level: they chose some 43,800 electors, fewer than 2 in every 1,000, who elected the deputies; in 1817, some 102,000, more than 3 in every 1,000, elected them directly (Meuriot, 1916, pp. 158 and 221–233; calculated). By the criterion "who elected the deputies", the change went upwards: it is the best test of "by what criterion?", and it is on the worksheet. And another nuance: in 1791 there were some 4.3 million active citizens against 2.7 million passive ones, and the website of France's Assemblée nationale warns: "Il est faux d'affirmer que 'seuls les riches pouvaient voter'" ("It is false to claim that 'only the rich could vote'").
- **Tocqueville, the classic of continuity.** In 1856 he wrote that in 1789 the French made the greatest effort ever "afin de couper pour ainsi dire en deux leur destinée" ("in order to cut their destiny in two, so to speak"), but that, "à leur insu" ("without knowing it"), they kept from the Ancien Régime most of the feelings, habits and even ideas with which they had made the Revolution (*L'Ancien Régime et la Révolution*, foreword; 7th ed., 1866, pp. i–ii). The title of his book II, chapter 2, sums it up: administrative centralisation is "une institution de l'ancien régime, et non pas l'œuvre de la révolution et de l'empire, comme on le dit" ("an institution of the Ancien Régime, and not the work of the Revolution and the Empire, as people say"). A good text to comment on at the end.
- **Hansa Mehta, in detail.** On 12-12-1947, in Geneva, she asked for "all men", which could be read as excluding women, to be changed to "human beings" or "persons"; Eleanor Roosevelt, who was chairing, replied that "men" already included everyone, and a note with that reading was approved (E/CN.4/SR.34, pp. 4–6). In 1948, the Commission on the Status of Women proposed "All people" (E/CN.4/81); India and the United Kingdom, "All people, men and women" (E/CN.4/99); and the Belgian delegate Lebeau, as a compromise, "all human beings", with the support of that commission (E/CN.4/SR.50, pp. 9–15). The UN says that Mehta "is widely credited" with the change, and also highlights Bodil Begtrup (Denmark) and Minerva Bernardino (Dominican Republic): that is the collective part of criterion 8.2. That is why the class says that Mehta was the first to ask for it, not that she did it alone.
- **What a peasant really paid.** There is no serious overall figure, and it is best not to give one. What went to the lord varied enormously from one region to another: in the Midi and south of Paris, some 3 or 4 hundredths of the gross product; in Brittany or Burgundy, much more (Goubert, p. 149). The

tithe was almost never a tenth: the usual rate was one sheaf in twelve or thirteen (Marion, 1923, p. 174). In Chalifert-en-Brie, in 1789, it was paid "à la onzième gerbe" ("at the eleventh sheaf") and, on wine, "la vingt et unième pièce" ("the twenty-first cask") (*Archives parlementaires*, vol. IV, p. 392).

- **From the 1789 decree to the 1793 one.** The king did not sign the August decrees: he only ordered them to be published (20 September), and they were promulgated on 3 November. In March 1790 the banalités and personal labour services fell without compensation, but it was the peasant who had to prove that a charge did not come from the land; in May, redemption was made indivisible and with arrears; in August 1792 the burden of proof was reversed; and in July 1793 everything fell without compensation, with the title deeds to be burned on 10 August. On how many people redeemed, Lefebvre had already warned in 1929: "il faut renoncer à dresser une statistique" ("we must give up on drawing up any statistics", p. 138); regional studies agree that very few did.
- **Did any woman vote in 1789?** A few, through a man: the regulation of 24-1-1789 allowed noblewomen who held a fief and communities of nuns to be represented by a proxy (arts. 11 and 20). The safe sentence is another one: the deputies were all men.
- **Backwards, after 1848 too.** The law of 31 May 1850 required three years' residence, proven through taxes, and the electorate fell from about 10 to about 7 million until December 1851 (Archives de Maine-et-Loire; Musée du compagnonnage). That is why the video does not say "for good".
- **Slavery, colony by colony.** The 1794 abolition was not applied in Martinique (occupied by the British), Réunion or Mauritius, and "free" meant obliged to stay on the plantation. In 1802, the law of 20 May "maintained" it where it had not been abolished; in Guadeloupe it was restored by a decree of 16 July, and in French Guiana by one of December, applied in 1803; in Saint-Domingue it was not, and Haiti became independent on 1-1-1804. The decree of 27-4-1848 freed some 250,000 people in the Antilles, Réunion and Senegal. The Bois-Caïman ceremony is a disputed tradition, not a proven fact.
- **The figures change depending on who is counting.** Sieyès counted "pas deux cent mille privilégiés" ("not two hundred thousand privileged") among "vingt-cinq à vingt-six millions d'âmes" ("twenty-five to twenty-six million souls"; ch. III): fewer than 1 in every 100 (calculated); Piketty, 1.5. A question for the classroom, with the four from class 1: why might it suit Sieyès to count few?
- **The new time.** By the calendar's official rule, the equinox one, 21 October 2026 was 29 Vendémiaire of year 235, the day of barley. The metre, compulsory in France from 1840, became compulsory in Spain from 1860 (law of 1849), with more than forty years of actual implementation (Centro Español de Metrología); and its definition changed in 1889, 1960 and 1983 (BIPM): the name lasts, not the definition. The Sceaux-Penthièvre cahier was already asking for it in April 1789.
- **The ages.** The dictionary of the Real Academia Española does not give 1789 ("desde fines del siglo XVIII o principios del XIX", "from the end of the 18th century or the beginning of the 19th"); Ribot (2016): in Spain 1789 "se utiliza habitualmente" ("is commonly used"); the Cambridge Faculty of History: contemporary history "lacks firm boundaries" (1918, 1930 or 1945). And Hobsbawm starts in 1789 because of a "dual revolution", the French one and the British Industrial Revolution (*The Age of Revolution*, 1962).

To find out more

- P. Seixas and T. Morton, *The Big Six Historical Thinking Concepts* (Nelson, 2013), "Historical Significance" and "Continuity and Change": https://historicalthinking.ca/historical-significance
- A. de Tocqueville, *L'Ancien Régime et la Révolution* (1856), on Wikisource: https://fr.wikisource.org/wiki/L%E2%80%99Ancien_R%C3%A9gime_et_la_R%C3%A9volution (in English, *The Old Regime and the Revolution*).
- E. J. Hobsbawm, *The Age of Revolution: Europe 1789–1848* (Weidenfeld & Nicolson, 1962).

Sources

Every fact, with its sources and its verbatim quotations, is in the class's verification record (in Spanish). The translations from French and Spanish are our own and literal; the Declaration of 1789, the Universal Declaration and the Spanish Constitution of 1978 are quoted in their official English versions, and texts written in English in the original. AP = *Archives parlementaires*, 1st series (on Persée: https://www.persee.fr/collection/arcpa).

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- The decree of 11-8-1789, arts. 1–9: AP, vol. VIII, pp. 397–398 · decrees of 15-3-1790 (AP, vol. XII, pp. 172–176) and 3-5-1790, arts. 3, 21 and 22 (AP, vol. XV, pp. 364–368), and their poster, the letters patent of 9-5-1790, art. XXI (Newberry Library, Case oversize FRC 10460 no. 3) · the tithes, until 1-1-1791: AP, vol. XII, p. 668 · law of 25-8-1792 (AP, vol. XLVIII, pp. 698–699) · decree of 17-7-1793, arts. 1, 2 and 6 (AP, vol. LXIX, p. 98; Duvergier, *Collection complète des lois*, vol. 6, pp. 23–24)
- The peasants who stop paying: G. Lefebvre, *Annales d'histoire économique et sociale* 1 (1929), pp. 138–140 · J.-N. Luc, *AHRF* 237 (1979), p. 492 · what they paid: M. Marion, *Dictionnaire des institutions de la France* (1923), pp. 34, 75, 83, 172–174, 397 and 526–530 · P. Goubert, *El Antiguo Régimen. 1. La sociedad* (Spanish edition, Siglo XXI, 1984), pp. 147–149 · J. Markoff, *MEFR* 103-1 (1991), pp. 59–60
- The cahiers de doléances: Gres-en-Brie, AP, vol. IV (1879), pp. 592–594 · Sceaux-Penthièvre, AP, vol. V (1879), pp. 115–116 · Chalifert-en-Brie, AP, vol. IV, p. 392
- Sieyès: *Qu'est-ce que le tiers état ?*, Champion edition (1888), opening and ch. III · *Préliminaire de la constitution* (20–21 July 1789), AP, vol. VIII, p. 259 · T. Piketty, *Capital et idéologie* (2019; in English, *Capital and Ideology*), table 2.1

- The vote: Constitution of 1791, title III, ch. I, sect. II, art. 2 · decree of 11-8-1792, art. 2 (AP, vol. XLVIII, pp. 29–30) · P. Meuriot, *Journal de la Société de statistique de Paris* 57 (1916), pp. 158–159, 221–233, 299 and 324–371: https://www.numdam.org/item/JSFS_1916__57__157_0/ · Assemblée nationale, pages on suffrage · the law of 31-5-1850: Archives de Maine-et-Loire and Musée du compagnonnage
- Women: ordinance of 21-4-1944, art. 17 (*Journal officiel*, Algiers, 22-4-1944; Digithèque MJP) · first vote, 29-4-1945: Assemblée nationale · regulation of 24-1-1789, arts. 11 and 20 (Duvergier, vol. 1)
- Slavery: decree of 16 Pluviôse Year II (4-2-1794), law of 30 Floréal Year X (20-5-1802) and decree of 27-4-1848 (Digithèque MJP) · Fondation pour la mémoire de l'esclavage · UNESCO · P. Girard (BnF)
- Condorcet: *Esquisse* (1795), p. 4 (Wikisource, facsimile) · Robinet, *Condorcet* (1893), pp. 320–323 · "Sur l'admission des femmes au droit de cité" (1790), *Œuvres*, vol. X (1847), p. 122
- The countryside: E. Le Roy Ladurie, *Annuaire du Collège de France 1980-1981*, pp. 613–614 · T. Loua, *Journal de la Société statistique de Paris* 21 (1880), pp. 175–176 · Observatoire des territoires (2022) · the regimes: Conseil constitutionnel · F. Braudel, *La Méditerranée* (2nd ed., 1966), vol. II, p. 223
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- Voting in Spain: Constitution of 1931, art. 36 (*Gaceta de Madrid*, 10-12-1931, p. 1581) · Congreso de los Diputados, "Elecciones 19 noviembre 1933" and "Las Cortes Españolas 1943-1977" · Decree 255 of 19-4-1937 · Law 1/1977, art. 2.2, and Royal Decree-law 20/1977, art. 2 · decree of 9-11-1868 and the electoral laws of 1878 and 1890
- The solutions from class 3: Imperial War Museums · Bundeszentrale für politische Bildung · *ABC* (Madrid), 10-11-1989, p. 1
- Teaching and learning: P. Lee (2005), in *How Students Learn: History, Mathematics, and Science in the Classroom* (National Research Council), pp. 44–45, https://doi.org/10.17226/10126 · J. M. Campillo-Ferrer, R. Sánchez-Ibáñez and B. Castro-Fernández (2025), *Aula Abierta* 54(3), 283–290 (in Spanish) · R. White and R. Gunstone, *Probing Understanding* (1992) · the reference videos, with their minute marks, in the class's review of reference videos
- Images: the Declaration, painting attributed to J.-J.-F. Le Barbier, c. 1789 (Musée Carnavalet, CC0); Sieyès, by Jacques-Louis David, 1817 (Harvard Art Museums; public domain); Condorcet, anonymous

portrait (Musée Carnavalet, CC0); the 1790 poster (Newberry Library; public domain); Pierre-Basile Lepaute's decimal clock, 1795 (Musée des Arts et Métiers; photo by Tieum512, CC BY 3.0); the map, from Natural Earth (public domain)

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